

Incident Severity & Escalation Matrix

Operational decision support for triage, escalation, communications, and response priority

Severity	Criteria	Examples	Required response
SEV-1 Critical	Material business outage, widespread compromise, ransomware, confirmed sensitive-data exposure, or high-impact privileged compromise.	Enterprise ransomware; major customer-data exposure; critical production compromise.	Immediate incident command; executive/legal/privacy engagement as applicable; continuous updates; aggressive containment.
SEV-2 High	Confirmed malicious activity with significant but bounded impact, privileged host compromise, or important service disruption.	Compromised admin workstation; serious DDoS; confirmed malware on business-critical host.	Rapid containment; incident lead assigned; frequent stakeholder updates; same-day action plan.
SEV-3 Medium	Suspicious or malicious activity with limited scope and no major business impact.	Single compromised user endpoint; blocked phishing with evidence of click but no sensitive access.	Analyst investigation; targeted containment; tracked remediation; manager visibility as needed.
SEV-4 Low	Informational event, benign positive, low-risk policy issue, or activity handled through routine workflow.	Scanner noise; blocked probe; non-impacting policy event.	Document disposition; tune detection or route to standard queue.

Escalation Factors

- Privileged or executive account involvement.
- Sensitive, regulated, or high-value data.
- Multiple systems, users, sites, or business units.
- Active attacker persistence or lateral movement.
- Loss of service availability or safety-critical operations.
- Uncertain scope with evidence of ongoing compromise.
- Legal, contractual, regulatory, or customer-notification implications.

Triage Questions

- What happened, and what evidence supports that conclusion?
- Is malicious activity confirmed, suspected, or disproven?
- What systems, users, data, and business processes are affected?
- Is the threat still active?
- What action can safely reduce risk immediately?
- What evidence must be preserved before containment?
- Who owns the affected service and who needs to know now?